

On abstinence and avoidance*

Maria Esipova
Bar-Ilan University

September 13, 2026

Abstract In this paper, I inspect two types of readings that emerge in a range of environments, such as in negative imperatives, under ‘not want’, under ‘fear’, etc.: (i) ABSTAIN readings, which convey willingness to prevent someone from intentionally engaging in some kind of act, and (ii) AVOID readings, which convey willingness to prevent a potentially unintended outcome. The ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction has a variety of grammatical reflexes cross-linguistically, e.g., anti-/re-licensing of ‘some’-indefinites in English: *Don’t call anyone!* (which asks the addressee to abstain from intentionally engaging in the activity of calling some person or other) vs. *Don’t (accidentally) call someone!* (which cautions the addressee against accidentally calling some person or other). I will focus on perfective vs. imperfective aspect and distribution of indefinites in Russian. I will argue that the relevant complements in ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases have distinct compositional structures: there is a situation layer in AVOID, but not in ABSTAIN cases. This will allow us to explain the relevant Russian facts about aspect and indefinites, but will also establish a framework for building accounts of grammatical reflexes of the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction cross-linguistically. The choice between the two compositional structures in the environments at hand is then driven by global pragmatic considerations about preventing unwanted scenarios, yielding the diverging inferences about intentional vs. accidental actions arising in the two cases.

1. Introduction

Two types of readings emerge in environments that convey willingness to prevent something from happening, such as negative imperatives, ‘not want’, ‘fear’, etc. In one of them, which I will call ABSTAIN readings, the speaker or the attitude holder wants to prevent someone from intentionally engaging in some kind of act. In the other, which I will call AVOID readings, the speaker or the attitude holder wants to prevent a potentially unintended outcome. Thus, in (1a), the speaker (i) tells the addressee to abstain from calling some person or other or (ii)–(iii) expresses their reluctance to engage in an act of calling some person or other—and the assumption in all these examples is that the potential agent of the potential calling is in control of whether or not they engage in this act. In (1b), the speaker is (i) warning the addressee against accidentally calling some person or other (e.g., they see that the addressee

*This work was first presented at the workshop ‘Agency and Intentions in Language (AIL) 1’ (Esipova 2021a) and the talk series ‘Slavic Linguistics Colloquium’ (Esipova 2021b). I thank the participants of those venues for discussion.

is about to sit on their phone), or (ii)–(iii) wants to avoid such an accident themselves (e.g., they say this while locking their phone before putting it in their pocket).

- (1) a. ABSTAIN:
 {(i) Don't call anyone! / (ii) I don't want to call anyone. / (iii) I'm afraid of calling anyone.}
 b. AVOID:
 {(i) Don't (accidentally) call someone! / (ii) I don't want to (accidentally) call someone. / (iii) I'm afraid of (accidentally) calling someone.}

Cross-linguistically, some grammatical phenomena are sensitive to the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction, such as the anti-/re-licensing of *some* indefinites in English, as seen in (1) (first observed in Szabolcsi 2004). Under the low-scope reading of the indefinite, only *any* indefinites are licensed under the ABSTAIN reading, but under the AVOID reading, *some* indefinites get re-licensed.¹

In this paper, I will primarily focus on how this distinction is tracked by imperfective vs. perfective aspect and distribution of indefinites in Russian, although I will also briefly discuss converging data from some other languages, with the expectation that the core empirical and analytical insights should generalize across languages.

The starting observation for Russian aspect (to be revised!) is that across the three environments we've evoked so far, verbs that are part of accomplishment descriptions are imperfective in ABSTAIN cases and perfective in AVOID ones. As for Russian indefinites,² the starting observation (to be refined!) is as follows. In negative imperatives and under 'not want' with infinitival complements, we have morphosyntactic negation that would normally be local enough to license negative concord items (NCIs). In these environments, dependent indefinites (*nibud'*) are not allowed in ABSTAIN cases, but NCIs (*ni*) are. However, both NCIs (*ni*) and dependent indefinites (*nibud'*) are in principle allowed in AVOID cases.³ Under 'fear'—where we don't have morphosyntactic negation and, thus, NCIs wouldn't be

¹As far as I can tell, *any* indefinites are also licensed under the AVOID reading, which mirrors the relevant facts from Russian and would thus be amenable to a similar explanation. That said, the inventory and licensing conditions of indefinites in Russian is very different from that of English, so we should be careful when drawing parallels.

²Indefinites in Russian (see, e.g., Haspelmath 1997 for an overview) are formed by attaching various affixes to indeterminate pronoun bases, which I systematically gloss as corresponding wh-items in this paper, as bare indeterminate pronoun bases are used as wh-items in Russian without any additional affixes. Bare indefinites also exist in Russian. As a first, rough approximation, they are licensed in a subset of cases in which *nibud'* indefinites are licensed, but there are seemingly further constraints on their distribution (see, e.g., Zanon 2022). They are also often stylistically marked. Because of these further complications, I set them aside for the purposes of this paper and will focus on *nibud'* indefinites only as the less marked dependent indefinites. Similarly, I only discuss *libo* indefinites as free choice indefinites, although, as far as I can tell, *by to ni bylo* free choice indefinites behave in the same way in the target environments as *libo* indefinites. I do not discuss specific indefinites (*-to*, *koe-*, *ne-*), known or unknown, at all.

³There appears to be some variation across Russian speakers regarding if they have a preference for *nibud'* indefinites over *ni* NCIs in these cases. I myself, being a native Russian speaker, accept both equally under negative imperatives, but sometimes find *ni* NCIs somewhat more marked under 'not want', depending on further factors, including word order. I will not explore these more fine-grained distinctions in this paper, but suffice it to say that naturalistic examples of both *ni* NCIs and *nibud'* indefinites in relevant AVOID cases abound. For instance, both versions of the example in (i) are widely attested in Google.

licensed—dependent indefinites (*nibud'*) are not allowed in ABSTAIN cases (instead we have to use, e.g., free choice indefinites, such as *libo*, as low-scope indefinites), but they are allowed in AVOID cases (in addition to, e.g., free choice indefinites). These observations are illustrated in (2)–(4).

- (2) a. Ne {zvoni / *pozvoni} {nikomu / *komu-nibud'}!
 not {call.IPFV.IMP / *call.PFV.IMP} {NI-who / *who-NIBUD'}
 'Don't call anyone!' (ABSTAIN)
- b. (Ostorožno!) Ne {*zvoni / pozvoni} (slučajno) {nikomu /
 (careful) not {*call.IPFV.IMP / call.PFV.IMP} (accidentally) {NI-who /
 komu-nibud'}!
 who-NIBUD'}
 '(Careful!) Don't (accidentally) call someone!' (AVOID)
- (3) a. Ja ne xoću {nikomu / *komu-nibud'} {zvoniť / *pozvoniť}.
 I not want {NI-who / *who-NIBUD'} {call.IPFV.INF / *call.PFV.INF}
 'I don't want to call anyone.' (ABSTAIN)
- b. Ja ne xoću {nikomu / komu-nibud'} (slučajno) {*zvoniť /
 I not want {NI-who / who-NIBUD'} (accidentally) {*call.IPFV.INF /
 pozvoniť}.
 call.PFV.INF}
 'I don't want to (accidentally) call someone.' (AVOID)
- (4) a. Ja bojus' {komu-libo / *komu-nibud'} {zvoniť / *pozvoniť}.
 I fear {who-LIBO / *who-NIBUD'} {call.IPFV.INF / *call.PFV.INF}
 'I am afraid of calling anyone.' (ABSTAIN)
- b. Ja bojus' {komu-libo / komu-nibud'} (slučajno) {*zvoniť /
 I fear {who-LIBO / who-NIBUD'} (accidentally) {*call.IPFV.INF /
 pozvoniť}.
 call.PFV.INF}
 'I'm afraid of (accidentally) calling someone.' (AVOID)

Some of the contrasts above have been discussed in the literature independently (and I elaborate a bit more on some of these discussions in subsection 3.1), but, to my knowledge, there hasn't been an attempt to put forward all of the data in (2)–(4) as a unified set of generalizations and to seek a unified treatment for it. The aspectual contrasts in negative imperatives in Russian and in Slavic in general are well-known and have been discussed, e.g., in Bogusławski 1985; Despić 2016, 2020; Goncharov 2018, among many others—although the way the relevant generalization is presented is often too simplistic, and I myself present it too simplistically here. I will revise and refine this generalization later in subsection 2.2. Zaliznjak (2006) discusses similar aspectual contrasts under 'fear', although only descriptively, and she doesn't connect them to the same aspectual contrasts in other environments. Goncharov (2020) discusses polarity-sensitive items, including *some* indefinites, under *want*

-
- (i) Ja ne xoću {ničego / što-nibud'} slomat'.
 I not want {NI-what / what-NIBUD'} break.PFV.INF
 'I don't want to break something.' (AVOID)

in English only and briefly mentions aspect in negative imperatives in Slavic as a potentially related phenomenon, but does not actually unify the two phenomena, nor does she make the connection to either aspect under ‘not want’ in Slavic or indefinites in Slavic in any of the environments above. Goncharov (2025) does present the aspect facts from Slavic in negative imperatives and under ‘not want’ as a unified phenomenon, with an attempt at a unified analysis (while also unifying them with subject obviation effects—more on this in subsections 2.4 and 3.1), however, she doesn’t discuss indefinites or ‘fear’.

In this paper, I will seek to not only account for the data above in a unified and principled way, but also, hopefully, to establish a framework for describing and accounting for grammatical reflexes of the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction cross-linguistically. The account I will propose will rely on the following core insights. First, the complements of the target operators in ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases have distinct compositional structures: there is an additional compositional layer in AVOID, but not in ABSTAIN cases. I will specifically propose that this additional layer is a “situation” layer. This will allow us to explain the relevant facts about aspect and indefinites. Second, the choice between the two compositional structures in the cases at hand is driven by global pragmatic considerations about preventing unwanted scenarios. This explains the distinct inferences about intentional vs. accidental actions arising in the two cases.

The rest of the paper is organized as follows. In section 2, I will do a deeper dive into the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction and its grammatical reflexes, refining the empirical generalizations for Russian. I will also adduce some additional converging data from other languages. In section 3, I first briefly review some of the previous attempts in the literature to account for some parts of what appears to be a more general phenomenon at hand. Then, I develop my own, more general account based on the core analytical insights anticipated above. In section 4, I discuss some additional facts about Russian aspect and how they can potentially be connected to the core analytical insight of the paper about the presence vs. absence of the additional situation layer. Section 5 concludes.

2. A deeper dive into ABSTAIN vs. AVOID

2.1. Introducing the *odnaždy* diagnostic

As the first step of our deeper dive into the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction, let us note that the Russian adverb *odnaždy* (‘once’, ‘one day’, ‘on one occasion’, etc.) is only compatible with AVOID sentences. Thus, we can use it as a diagnostic for now, but we will also be able to capture this fact within the analysis developed in section 3. This constraint on *odnaždy* is illustrated in (5).

- (5) a. Ne {*otkryvaj / otkroj} odnaždy škaf (slučajno)!
 not {*open.IPFV.IMP / open.PFV.IMP} once closet (accidentally)
 ‘Don’t open the closet (accidentally) one day!’ (only AVOID)
- b. Ja {ne xoču / bojus’} odnaždy (slučajno) {*otkryvat’ /
 I {not want / fear} once (accidentally) {*open.IPFV.INF /
 otkryt’} škaf.
 open.PFV.INF} closet
 ‘{I don’t want to (accidentally) open the closet one day. / I am afraid of (acci-

dentally) opening the closet one day.}’ (only AVOID)

2.2. Refining the generalizations about ABSTAIN vs. AVOID

Next, let us note that the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction holds at the utterance level, not at the level of, e.g., specific verb forms. Thus, both sentences in (6) are AVOID cases (they have *odnaždy*). The part of the situation outside the agent’s control is if they see a monster or hear a scraping sound; the closet opening is intentional (as indicated by the purposive clause), and the aspect choice is determined solely by its placement relative to the reference time (i.e., perfective vs. imperfective have the standard viewpoint aspect interpretation).

- (6) a. Ja ne xoču odnaždy otkryt’ škaf, čtoby dostat’ noski, i uvidet’
 I not want once open.PFV.INF closet to get socks and see.PFV.INF
 tam monstra.
 there monster
 ‘I don’t want to one day open the closet to get socks and see a monster there.’
 b. Ja ne xoču odnaždy otkryvat’ škaf, čtoby dostat’ noski, i
 I not want once open.IPFV.INF closet to get socks and
 uslyšat’ skrežet.
 hear.PFV.INF scrape
 ‘I don’t want to one day be opening the closet to get socks and hear a scraping sound.’

In (7), I provide some naturalistic examples from Google illustrating the same point.

- (7) a. Ne xoču odnaždy otkryt’ xolodil’nik i ne obnaružit’ tam
 not want once open.PFV.INF fridge and not discover.PFV.INF there
 ničego krome ovošej.
 NI-what except vegetables
 ‘I don’t want to one day open the fridge and find nothing but vegetables there.’
 b. Ja ne xoču odnaždy sidet’ na kuxne i uslyšat’ zvonok.
 I not want once sit.IPFV.INF in kitchen and hear.PFV.INF call
 ‘I don’t want to one day be sitting in the kitchen and hear a phone call.’

Note that in the conjunctive AVOID cases above, the imperfective predicates all describe a background event, not the event that is the core of the undesirable scenario—the latter are all perfective. There are, however, AVOID cases, at least with ‘not want’ and ‘fear’, where the core undesirable eventuality is some kind of state and, thus, the relevant verb is imperfective. Such are the naturalistic examples in (8), where the core undesirable eventuality is a state, and imperfective has its standard viewpoint aspect interpretation.

- (8) a. ja ne xoču odnaždy sidet’ vozle tvojej bol’ničnoj krovati
 I not want once sit.IPFV.INF near your hospital bed
 ‘I don’t want to one day be sitting by your hospital bed.’
 b. ne xoču odnaždy ležat’ ubitym na ulice
 not want once lie.IPFV.INF murdered on street
 ‘I don’t want to one day be lying murdered in the street.’

- c. Ja očen' bojus' odnaždy sidet' u dveri s bumažkoj: « My staralis',
 I very fear once sit.IPFV.INF at door with paper we tried
 no ne vyvezli».
 but not managed
 'I'm very afraid of one day be sitting at the door with a piece of paper (saying)
 'We tried, but failed'.'

So, the correct generalization—and already a crucial informal analytical insight—for aspect in ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases is as follows. In AVOID cases, we get the standard viewpoint aspect interpretation of perfective vs. imperfective (how the event is situated with respect to the reference time). In ABSTAIN cases, we get “meaningless” imperfective, i.e., imperfective that is inserted as a morphosyntactic default when the event is not situated with respect to any reference time—in fact, I will propose that there is no reference time and, thus, no viewpoint aspect in those cases.

Now let me add a caveat that with negative imperatives, we don't seem to actually ever get meaningful viewpoint imperfective. Even AVOID negative imperatives still assume more agency/control from the relevant individual than cases with 'not want' or 'fear' like (8), so the negative imperative counterpart of (8b) in (9) is odd because of this.

- (9) #Ne leži odnaždy ubitym na ulice!
 not lie.IPFV.INF once murdered on street
 Intended: 'Don't one day be lying murdered in the street!'

As for conjunctive examples like (6b), with an imperfective predicate describing a background event that the relevant individual does have control over, they can't be replicated with negative imperatives, because in Russian, we simply cannot coordinate two verbal projections, imperative or not, under a single clausemate negation. We can coordinate two negative imperatives, but that, of course, has the interpretation of two independent negative directives.

In Table 1, I summarize the relevant grammatical reflexes of ABSTAIN vs. AVOID in Russian in the target environments.

	ABSTAIN	AVOID
aspect	imperfective only	imperfective or perfective depending on standard viewpoint aspect considerations
indefinites (in the scope of the relevant operator)	negative imperatives, 'not want' with infinitival complements	
	NCIs (<i>ni</i>): ✓	NCIs (<i>ni</i>): ✓ (but can be marked)
	dependent indefinites (<i>nibud'</i>): ✗	dependent indefinites (<i>nibud'</i>): ✓
	'fear'	
	free choice indefinites (<i>libo</i>): ✓	free choice indefinites (<i>libo</i>): ✓
	dependent indefinites (<i>nibud'</i>): ✗	dependent indefinites (<i>nibud'</i>): ✓

Table 1: Grammatical reflexes of ABSTAIN vs. AVOID in Russian

2.3. ABSTAIN vs. AVOID in other environments

While, the environments discussed so far are the main focus of this paper, there exist other environments that are sensitive to the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction—or potentially to some related distinctions.

One obvious environment of this kind is, of course, negative directives embedded under ‘ask’, ‘plead’, etc. Unsurprisingly, the relevant contrasts can all be replicated in this environment, as shown in (10). Thus, in (10a), Lena’s request implied that Zhenya could prevent all breaking events, while in (10b), Lena’s request was for Zhenya to try to avoid accidentally breaking anything—with the same consequences for aspect and indefinites as before.

- (10) a. Lena poprosila Ženju ne lomat’ {ničego / *čto-nibud’}.
 Lena asked Zhenya not break.IPFV.INF {NI-what / *what-NIBUD’}
 ‘Lena asked Zhenya not to break anything.’ (ABSTAIN)
- b. Lena poprosila Ženju ne slomat’ {ničego / čto-nibud’}
 Lena asked Zhenya not break.PFV.INF {NI-what / what-NIBUD’}
 (slučajno).
 (accidentally)
 ‘Lena asked Zhenya not to break something (accidentally).’ (AVOID)

Another obvious environment, which also behaves as expected, is various ways of expressing desires, preferences, etc. for something not happening other than ‘not want’—as shown in (11) for ‘it is important/desirable that not *p*’.

- (11) a. {Važno / želatel’no}, čtoby Dima {ničego / *čto-nibud’} ne
 {important / desirable} that.SUBJ Dima {NI-what / *what-NIBUD’} not
 lomal.
 break.IPFV.SUBJ
 ‘It is important/desirable that Dima not break anything.’ (ABSTAIN)
- b. {Važno / želatel’no}, čtoby Dima {ničego / čto-nibud’}
 {important / desirable} that.SUBJ Dima {NI-what / what-NIBUD’}
 (slučajno) ne slomal.
 (accidentally) not break.PFV.SUBJ
 ‘It is important/desirable that Dima not (accidentally) break something.’
 (AVOID)

The final—and less obvious—environment I will look at is root modals with negation. While many root modals resist AVOID readings, because they ostensibly only talk about permissions and obligations pertaining to things that can be fully controlled, some modals do allow for both interpretations (contra some of the empirical claims in Goncharov 2018). Thus, under the $\Box\neg$ root reading of *ne dolžen* ($\approx$ ‘not must’), in (12a), the speaker once again implies that the addressee can control the breaking events and obliges the addressee not to engage in them, while in (12b), the speaker obliges the addressee to try their best to avoid accidentally breaking something.

- (12) a. Vy ne dolžny {ničego / *čto-nibud’} lomat’. (root, $\Box\neg$)
 You not must {NI-what / *what-NIBUD’} break.IPFV.INF

- ≈‘You must not break anything.’ (ABSTAIN)
- b. Vy ne dolžny {ničego / čto-nibud’} (slučajno) slomat’. (root, $\Box\neg$)
 You not must {NI-what / what-NIBUD’} (accidentally) break.IPFV.INF
 ≈‘You must not (accidentally) break something.’ (AVOID)

Note that this contrast is still about preventability, not about who the target of the obligation is (also contra Goncharov 2018). Thus, in both cases in (12), the obligation is on the subject. In contrast, in (13), the obligation is not on the subject, but on the addressee. The ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction still obtains in both cases, and the difference is about how much control the target of the obligation has over all the stages of the potential event, not whether the subject is the target of the obligation.

- (13) a. *Context: A vet is giving instructions to a cat’s owner for the morning before the surgery.*
 Kot ne dolžen {ničego / *čto-nibud’} jest’ do
 cat not must {NI-what / *what-NIBUD’} eat.IPFV.INF before
 operaciji. (root, $\Box\neg$)
 surgery
 ≈‘The cat isn’t allowed to eat anything before the surgery.’ (ABSTAIN)
- b. *Context: A cat’s owner is giving instructions to a cat-sitter, asking them to make sure that the cat doesn’t accidentally get into the medicine cabinet and eat something from there.*
 Kot ne dolžen {ničego / čto-nibud’} slučajno sjest’
 cat not must {NI-what / what-NIBUD’} accidentally eat.PFV.INF
 otsjuda. (root, $\Box\neg$)
 from-here
 ≈‘You can’t let the cat accidentally eat something from here.’ (AVOID)

AVOID examples of the $\Box\neg$ root reading of *ne dolžen* (≈‘not must’) are also widely attested in the wild, with some of these provided in (14).

- (14) a. Vy ne dolžny uronit’ granatu, inače granata vzorvëtsja.
 you not must drop.PFV.INF grenade otherwise grenade will-explode
 ‘You shouldn’t drop the grenade, otherwise the grenade will explode.’ (AVOID;
 the target of the obligation is the subject)
- b. Deti ili domašnije pitomcy ne dolžny slučajno s"jest’ primanku.
 children or domestic pets not must accidentally eat.PFV.INF bait
 ‘Children or pets shouldn’t accidentally eat the bait.’ (AVOID; the target of the
 obligation is not the subject)

Now, for $\neg\Diamond$ with some possibility root modals, we ostensibly get a seemingly related, but clearly not identical difference between deontic readings (prohibitions, where we prohibit engaging in any kind of door-opening events) vs. circumstantial readings (we don’t want to prevent anything, we’re just saying that a certain outcome can’t be obtained), as illustrated in (15) and (16). However, since this distinction is not fully identical to the ABSTAIN vs.

AVOID distinction,⁴ I will not explore it further in this paper.

- (15) a. Ja ne mogu otkryvat' ètu dver'. (root, $\neg\Diamond$)
 I not can open.IPFV.INF this door
 ≈‘I am not allowed to open this door.’ (ABSTAIN; prohibition)
- b. Ja ne mogu otkryt' ètu dver'. (root, $\neg\Diamond$)
 I not can open.PFV.INF this door
 ≈‘I am not able to open this door.’ (inability)
- (16) a. Ètu dver' nel'zja otkryvat'. (root, $\neg\Diamond$)⁵
 this door NOT-CAN open.IPFV.INF
 ≈‘This door mustn’t be opened.’ (ABSTAIN; prohibition)
- b. Ètu dver' nel'zja otkryt'. (root, $\neg\Diamond$)
 this door NOT-CAN open.PFV.INF
 ≈‘It’s impossible to open this door.’ (inability)

2.4. What ABSTAIN vs. AVOID isn’t

It is important to note that the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction is not reducible to whatever distinctions are responsible for the so-called subject obviation constraint and cases when it is lifted. The latter has been discussed a lot in the literature (see, e.g., Ruwet 1984/1991; Farkas 1992; Schlenker 2005; Szabolcsi 2021, among many others). It is a pretty complex phenomenon, but the general idea is that normally, the subject of a subjunctive clause embedded under an attitude predicate should be disjoint in reference from the attitude holder subject of the matrix clause (the *subject obviation constraint*). If we do want them to be co-referential, we would normally use infinitival clauses instead, as illustrated for French in (17a). However, the subject obviation constraint is lifted if we introduce, in the words of Ruwet (1984/1991), “a certain distance between self and self”. Thus, (17b) can be acceptable, for example, under a non-*de se* reading (e.g., Nina doesn’t recognize that her desire is about herself or maybe she is talking about her character in a play, etc.). Note that (17a), in contrast, is obligatorily *de se*.

- (17) French
- a. Nina veut partir.
 Nina wants leave.INF
 ‘Nina wants to leave.’ (“neutral”, but obligatorily *de se*)
- b. Nina_i veut qu’elle_i parte.
 Nina wants that’she leave.SUBJ
 ‘Nina wants that she leave.’ (some kind of distancing “between self and self”)

⁴It’s also a complicated and often subtle distinction in and of itself. For one thing, circumstantial inability can hold because there is a prohibition:

- (i) Ja ne mogu otkryt' ètu dver', potomu što mne nel'zja eë otkryvat'. (root, $\neg\Diamond$)
 I not can open.PFV.INF this door because me.DAT NOT-CAN it open.IPFV.INF
 ≈‘I am not able to open this door, because I am not allowed to open it.’ (inability because of a prohibition)

⁵*Ne-l’zja* is etymologically ‘not-can’, but synchronically, it functions as a single frozen lexical item.

Russian also demonstrates subject obviation effects, with similar intuitions about when this constraint can be lifted, as shown in (18).

- (18) a. Nina xočet ujtí.
 Nina wants leave.INF
 ‘Nina wants to leave.’ (‘neutral’, but obligatorily *de se*)
 b. Nina_i xočet čtoby ona_i ušla.
 Nina wants that.SUBJ she leave.SUBJ
 ‘Nina wants that she leave.’ (some kind of distancing “between self and self”)

However, while the contrasts above are sometimes talked about in terms of how much control the agent has over their actions (and they are not fully reducible to the *de se* vs. non-*de se* distinction either—at least not at the level of individuals), they are clearly distinct from the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction and its grammatical reflexes.

First, as we have already seen in multiple examples above, starting with (3), the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction obtains for infinitival embedded clauses whose subjects are necessarily controlled by the matrix subject, such as ‘I don’t want to leave’ (i.e., the subject obviation constraint doesn’t apply).

Next, the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction also obtains for finite embedded clauses where the subject of the matrix clause and the subject of the embedded clause are not co-referential (i.e., the subject obviation constraint is obeyed), as illustrated in (19).

- (19) *Context: I am directing a movie and...*
 a. ...*I am having second thoughts about a certain scene.*
 Ja ne xoču, čtoby Nina {ubivala / #ubila} Anju (v ètoj
 I not want that.SUBJ Nina {kill.IPFV.SUBJ / #kill.PFV.SUBJ} Anya (in this
 scene).
 scene)
 ‘I don’t want Nina to kill Anya (in this scene).’ (ABSTAIN)
 b. ...*I want to make sure my actors are safe.*
 (Prover’te rekvizit!) Ja ne xoču, čtoby Nina (slučajno)
 (check prop) I not want that.SUBJ Nina (accidentally)
 {#ubivala / ubila} Anju.
 {#kill.IPFV.SUBJ / kill.PFV.SUBJ} Anya
 ‘(Check the prop!) I don’t want Nina to (accidentally) kill Anya.’ (AVOID)

Finally and most crucially, the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction obtains in subjunctive embedded clauses where the matrix subject and the overt embedded subject are co-referential, but the subject obviation constraint is lifted, as illustrated in (20). In both examples in (20), the subject obviation constraint is felicitously lifted due to the separation between the matrix attitude holder (the speaker) and the embedded subject (the speaker’s character). However, (20a) is still an ABSTAIN case, where killing would not be accidental—and we get the default imperfective in the embedded clause.⁶ Meanwhile, (20b) is still an AVOID case, where killing

⁶Note, by the way, that it doesn’t have to be the attitude holder, nor the embedded subject who ultimately has the control over preventing the relevant events in ABSTAIN cases—in (20a), for instance, it is the director.

would be accidental—and we get perfective in the embedded clause, with its standard viewpoint aspect interpretation. In other words, the subject obviation constraint can be lifted without affecting the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction and its grammatical reflexes.

- (20) a. *Context: Nina and I are actors in a movie, and we're about to shoot the next scene, where my character was originally supposed to kill Nina's character. However, I suddenly realize that I don't like this writing decision and would like to request a change to the script:*
 Ja ne xoču, čtoby ja {ubivala / #ubila} Ninu v
 I not want that.SUBJ I {kill.IPFV.SUBJ / #kill.PFV.SUBJ} Nina in
 sledujušej scene.
 next scene
 'I don't want that I [= my character] kill Nina [= Nina's character] in the next scene.' (ABSTAIN)
- b. *Context: We are playing DnD, and we are in a fight. It's my move, and I (i.e., my character) could shoot my longbow at the enemy now, but Nina's character is in my way, and if I shoot from my current position, I might accidentally kill them. It's not in my—or anyone's—power to prevent that, though—how well I execute the shot literally depends on a roll of the dice. So I choose to spend my next move moving to a better position instead. I explain my decision to the group:*
 Ja ne xoču, čtoby ja (slučajno) {#ubivala / ubila}
 I not want that.SUBJ I (accidentally) {#kill.IPFV.SUBJ / kill.PFV.SUBJ}
 Ninu.
 Nina
 'I don't want that I [= my character] accidentally kill Nina [= Nina's character].'
 (AVOID)

The bottom line is that whatever the meaning-related phenomenon tracked by the subject obviation constraint and cases when it is lifted is, it is independent of the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction, and Russian imperfective vs. perfective and indefinite distribution in the target environments track the latter and not the former. Thus, while it is possible that the two phenomena may interact or correlate in certain aspects, we still need distinct analyses for them.

2.5. ABSTAIN vs. AVOID in other languages

Before I proceed to develop an account for the data above, let me illustrate the cross-linguistic ubiquity of the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction having grammatical reflexes for several other languages by adducing a selection of relevant examples from various languages, generously provided by various linguists. I will not attempt to develop complete and detailed generalizations for any of those languages; all these examples should be taken as quick glimpses of potential directions for developing such generalizations. Similarly, while I would expect the core analytical insights from the next section to apply cross-linguistically, the

What matters is that the relevant events can in principle be prevented by someone's executive decision.

specific implementations will inevitably vary depending on how the relevant grammatical phenomena work in a given language.

In (21a), we have a paradigm from German, courtesy of Felicitas Andermann (p.c.), with the following comment from the latter: “[I]n German, the ABSTAIN reading licenses *niemanden* (‘nobody’) but not *nicht jemanden* (‘not someone’). In (21b-i), under the AVOID reading, on the other hand, both *niemanden* and *nicht jemanden* are acceptable, although *nicht jemanden* is highly marked. When the adverbial *versehentlich* (‘by.mistake’) is added, *nicht jemanden* is fully acceptable, as in (21b-ii), while *niemanden* is but marginally acceptable when preceding *versehentlich*, as in (21b-iv), and (for me) almost unacceptable when following *versehentlich*, as in (21b-iii).”

(21) German

- a. ABSTAIN:
Ruf {niemanden / *nicht jemanden} an
call.IMP {nobody / *not someone} up
- b. AVOID:
(i) Ruf {niemanden / (?)nicht jemanden} an
call.IMP {nobody / (?)not someone} up
(ii) Ruf nicht versehentlich jemanden an
call.IMP not by.mistake someone up
(iii) ?*Ruf versehentlich niemanden an
call.IMP by.mistake nobody up
(iv) ?Ruf niemanden versehentlich an
call.IMP nobody by.mistake up

In (22), we have a paradigm from Slovenian, courtesy of Kristina Gregorčič (p.c.), with the following comment from the latter: “...commands in AVOID cases cannot be expressed with the imperative; they are formed with the particle *bi* used to express conditional mood instead.” (22) also shows that the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction has consequences for indefinite distribution in Slovenian (at least in negative directives), that partially resemble the Russian facts: only *ni* NCIs are licensed in ABSTAIN negative directives, while a variety of other indefinites (but not *ni* NCIs, at least not for this speaker) are licensed in AVOID negative directives.

(22) Slovenian

- a. {Nikogar / *kogarkoli / *koga / *nekoga} ne kliči.
{NI-who / *who-KOLI / *who / *NE-who} not call.IPFV.IMP
‘Don’t call anyone.’ (ABSTAIN)
- b. Da ne bi po nesreči {*nikogar / kogarkoli / koga / ?nekoga}
that not would by accident {*NI-who / who-KOLI / who / ?NE-who}
poklicala.
call.PFV
‘Don’t accidentally call someone.’ (AVOID)

Finally, in (23), we have a paradigm from Kildin Saami, courtesy of Alexander Sergienko

(p.c.), with the following comment from the latter: “The prohibitives with AVOID readings show both perfective (23a) and imperfective (23b) aspectual markers, as well as verbs not marked for aspect (23c). On the contrary, ABSTAIN prohibitives can only be combined with imperfective (23d) or unmarked aspect (23e).”

(23) Kildin Saami

- a. Jel’ kadc-es’t’ gr’iib
PROH catch-PERF flu.ACC
‘Don’t catch the flu!’ (AVOID)
- b. Jel’l’e maŋŋn-an’n’t-e urk-et’
PROH.PL be.late-IPFV1-PL class-PL.ACC
‘Don’t be late for classes!’ (AVOID)
- c. Jel’ maŋŋen’ pojs-e
PROH be.late train-ACC
‘Don’t be late for your train!’ (AVOID)
- d. Jel’ vel’l’s-el soan-en’
PROH jump.off-IPFV2 sled-LOC.PL
‘Don’t jump off the sled!’ (ABSTAIN)
- e. Jel’l’e poačk-e, nadj-edd-e min’n’-e.
PROH.PL run.away-PL hope-MID-IMP.PL 1SG-DAT
‘Don’t run away, have faith in me.’ (ABSTAIN)”

3. Analysis

3.1. Prior literature and desiderata for a general account

There have been attempts to formally account for the aspectual facts in Slavic negative imperatives. Thus, Despić (2016, 2020) offers a purely syntactic account. Briefly, this account relies on the idea that imperfective is syntactically higher than perfective in Slavic, and that in negative imperatives, perfective ends up being in a lower phase and, thus, unavailable for agreement with the imperative probe—whereas imperfective is still available. Then, cases when the relevant action is interpreted as accidental (AVOID readings in my terms) are posited to lack the transitive, agent-introducing head *v*, which results in the relevant constituent being a weak phase or not a phase at all, so perfective is available for agreement.

Goncharov (2018) criticizes Despić’s account on essentially being “too syntactic” and missing the fact that the correlation between aspect and meaning-related effects in negative imperatives obtains for any type of verb, including agentive transitive verbs (a criticism that I agree with). Goncharov then offers a semantic–pragmatic alternative, which builds on an oft expressed intuition (pursued analytically, e.g., in Zinova & Filip 2014) that there is pragmatic competition between imperfective and perfective in Slavic: “...a command to not open the window with the perfective forbids the addressee to succeed in opening the window leaving it open whether an attempt to open the window can be made. The use of imperfective makes a stronger prohibition against attempting to open the window.” (Goncharov 2018, p. 3). To formalize this intuition, Goncharov (2018) then relies on an ad hoc intentionality operator in ABSTAIN cases.

Goncharov (2020) discusses polarity-sensitive items, including *some* indefinites, under *want* in English only. She proposes an intervening presupposition that “shields” *some* from anti-licensing in AVOID cases like (1b). Note that the insight that something is “shielding” *some* from being anti-licensed in such cases is already present in Szabolcsi 2004, who doesn’t develop this idea further, though. However, Szabolcsi’s idea was that there is something in the compositional (i.e., syntactic–semantic structure) that is doing the shielding, not a presupposition. This is ultimately the insight that I will pursue in my analysis.

Finally, Goncharov (2025) talks about aspect in Slavic both in negative imperatives and under ‘not want’. She also seeks to offer a unified account of the aspectual facts in Slavic and cross-linguistic subject obviation facts. The details of the analysis she proposes don’t matter, however, because I believe that there are more fundamental issues with this approach. First, as I discuss in subsection 2.4, I believe that attempts to unify subject obviation with the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction are misguided. Second, the account proposed in Goncharov 2025 is still not general enough, as it ignores indefinite distribution facts (Goncharov (2025) briefly mentions the data on polarity-sensitive items in English at the end, but doesn’t attempt to extend her analysis to those data).

This latter criticism applies to all these accounts above: none of them is general enough. Instead, we want an account that would give us tools to explain all the various grammatical reflexes of the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction across languages and across environments. However, we still want it to be properly constrained (e.g., again, we don’t actually want our account to have direct consequences for subject obviation effects). We want our analysis to properly capture both the meaning-related and the syntactic aspects of the target phenomena, establishing an appropriate division of labor between syntax, semantics, and pragmatics. Finally, we want our account to apply at the correct level, in particular, capturing the utterance-level nature of the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction, discussed in 2.2 (cf., e.g., Despić’s account, which relies on the properties of individual verbs).

3.2. Summary of the analysis

In the rest of this section, I will develop a general and principled analysis for the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction and its grammatical reflexes, preserving two insights from prior work. First, there is indeed a (general) pragmatic competition between the two cases, but (i) it is not directly hard-coded into the lexical semantics of any specific items, and (ii) there are also compositional differences between the two. Second, something does indeed “shield” polarity-sensitive items, such as *nibud’* or *some* indefinites, from anti-licensing in AVOID cases under negation, but it’s something in the compositional structure (i.e., in line with the original insight in Szabolcsi 2004).

More specifically, I propose that the target clauses in ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases have distinct compositional (i.e., syntactic–semantic) structures (in contrast to Goncharov’s work). More specifically, in AVOID cases, the target clause has a situation layer, with the events described by the verbs situated with respect to the situation’s runtime, which corresponds to the notion of *reference time* from Reichenbach 1947. In other words, in AVOID sentences we actually have viewpoint aspect in the target clause. In contrast, in ABSTAIN cases, there is no situation layer in the target clause. Instead, we have descriptions of “unsituated events”, i.e., we don’t have viewpoint aspect.

I then make the following assumptions about Russian aspect. Contrary to what is assumed in much of prior literature (including, e.g., Goncharov’s work on the relevant phenomena), I will maintain that Russian imperfective doesn’t always express viewpoint aspect. It does so only when there is a situation layer, and then, as expected, it can, e.g., place the event’s endpoints outside the situation’s runtime. But if there is no situation layer, it gets inserted as a morphosyntactic default for unsituated events. As for perfective, it always expresses viewpoint aspect (e.g., placing the culmination of the event within the situation’s runtime) and, thus, always requires a situation layer.

Then, for indefinites, I propose that the situation layer can also re-license dependent indefinites by making negation too non-local for licensing *ni* NCIs in certain configurations.

Finally, I propose that pragmatic considerations affect the choice between the two compositional structures when we’re talking about preventing undesirable scenarios; these considerations are global and don’t rely, e.g., on lexical presuppositions of specific items (contra, again, some of Goncharov’s work on the relevant phenomena).

3.3. Events, situations, and worlds

I will assume an ontology that includes *events*, *situations*, and *worlds*—as summarized in (24). This rich ontology is not strictly speaking necessary for implementing the main analytical insights of this paper, however, I find this three-way distinction conceptually appealing.

- (24)
- a. Events: variable e , type v
 - b. Worlds: variable w , type w ; ultimate mega-containers for all events
 - c. Situations: variable s , type s ; “snapshots” of worlds or “little videos” that stretch in time and space and can, thus, “capture” multiple different events fully or partially⁷

I then assume that events, situations, and worlds are organized mereologically, with some properties of this structure, as well as the relevant notational conventions, summarized in (25).

- (25)
- a. An event can be contained in a world: $e \subseteq w$ (here $\subseteq$ indicates mereological containment, not subsethood)
 - b. A situation can be contained in a world: $s \subseteq w$
 - c. An event can overlap with a situation: $e \circ s$
 - d. A specific case of such overlap is when an event is fully contained within a situation: $e \subseteq s$

Next, events, situations, and worlds differ in if/how they are introduced compositionally.

I assume that declarative sentences denote *propositions*, i.e., sets of worlds, and worlds are part of the lexical meaning of all predicates.

Events get introduced as part of the lexical meaning of some predicates. I will specifically adopt an ontologically enriched version of quantificational event semantics from Champollion 2015. E.g., the entry for ‘open’ is provided in (26).

⁷The notion of *situations* has, of course, been used in all sorts of ways in the literature (see, e.g., Kratzer 2021 for an overview), but this is how I will conceptualize it here.

$$(26) \quad \llbracket \text{open} \rrbracket = \lambda f_{vt} \lambda w_w. \exists e_v. f(e) \wedge e \subseteq w \wedge \text{open}(e)$$

Situations are only sometimes introduced into the compositional structure of a clause. If a situation layer is introduced, the lexically introduced events within that clause then get situated relative to the situation’s runtime (which, again, plays the same role as *reference time* in Reichenbach 1947). Now, there are many ways to cut the pie compositionally, but the situation-introducing modifier in (27) will do, and I will make the following additional assumptions. First, any further regular event modifiers undergo an appropriate type-shift to include situations. Second, some lexical items are sensitive to whether their input has a situation layer. Third, similarly to e , s is existentially closed off at the end, if nothing else binds it.

$$(27) \quad \llbracket \text{SIT} \rrbracket = \lambda V_{\langle vt, wt \rangle} \lambda f_{vt} \lambda s_s \lambda w_w. s \subseteq w \wedge V(\lambda e. f(e) \wedge e \circ s)(w)$$

I will remain agnostic about the exact inventory of clause types that require situations (and, consequently, viewpoint aspect) vs. those that can have them optionally vs. those that cannot have them (if the latter even exist). Suffice it to say that at least in Russian, infinitival clauses, imperative clauses, and subjunctive clauses all can, but don’t have to have the situation layer.

3.4. Situations and Russian aspect

As anticipated in section 3.2, in Russian, imperfective doesn’t always require a situation layer (i.e., imperfective verbs can describe unsituated events), but perfective does. I will thus posit two types of the IPFV head: a “vacuous”⁸ one in (28a), combining with a situation-less verbal projection (a morphosyntactic default), and a “meaningful” one, e.g., one that describes events whose runtime contains the situation’s runtime ($\text{rt}(s) \subseteq \text{rt}(e)$),⁹ as in (28b), with the result of combining this head with ‘open’ given in (28c).

$$(28) \quad \begin{array}{ll} \text{a.} & \llbracket \text{IPFV}_{\text{vac}} \rrbracket = \lambda V_{\langle vt, wt \rangle} \lambda f_v \lambda w_w. V(\lambda e. f(e))(w) \\ \text{b.} & \llbracket \text{IPFV}_{\text{sit}} \rrbracket = \lambda S_{\langle vt, \langle s, wt \rangle \rangle} \lambda f_v \lambda s_s \lambda w_w. S(\lambda e. f(e) \wedge \text{rt}(s) \subseteq \text{rt}(e))(s)(w) \\ \text{c.} & \llbracket [\llbracket \text{open} \rrbracket \text{ SIT}] \text{ IPFV}_{\text{sit}} \rrbracket = \lambda f_v \lambda s_s \lambda w_w. s \subseteq w \wedge \exists e. f(e) \wedge \text{rt}(s) \subseteq \text{rt}(e) \wedge e \circ s \wedge e \subseteq w \wedge \text{open}(e) \end{array}$$

Russian perfective always expresses viewpoint aspect, so there is no vacuous version of the PFV head, it always combines with a situation-full verbal projection; e.g., perfective verbs can describe events that culminate within the situation’s runtime ($\text{culm}(e) \subseteq \text{rt}(s)$), as in (29).

$$(29) \quad \llbracket \text{PFV} \rrbracket = \lambda S_{\langle vt, \langle s, wt \rangle \rangle} \lambda f_v \lambda s_s \lambda w_w. S(\lambda e. f(e) \wedge \text{culm}(e) \subseteq \text{rt}(s))(s)(w)$$

Note that, as is, instead of compositionally separating the situation-introducing item from the viewpoint aspect item, we could have combined them into a single item. As I said before, there are many ways to cut this pie compositionally. Subjectively, I find the structure where

⁸The “vacuous” imperfective isn’t completely vacuous; it still has its atelic, mass-noun-y, plural-y interpretation—but no viewpoint aspect interpretation (because there is no viewpoint).

⁹Of course, the specific formulations of meaningful viewpoint aspect contributions of imperfective vs. perfective can be refined as necessary and are orthogonal to the main insight here.

we separate the introduction of the viewpoint (i.e., the situation) from positioning the event relative to this viewpoint (i.e., viewpoint aspect) cleaner. Whether or not there are more objective empirical or analytical arguments in favor of this separation remains to be seen.

3.5. Compositional structure of the cases at hand

We are now in a position to specify the compositional structures for the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases at hand.

As said before, I propose that the relevant clauses in AVOID cases have a situation layer, but those in ABSTAIN cases don't. Note that this immediately allows us to account for the distribution of *odnaždy* ('once') from subsection 2.1 if we posit that *odnaždy* quantifies over situations: there is simply nothing for it to quantify over in ABSTAIN cases.

For concreteness and simplicity, I will then assume a Kaufmann 2012-style imperative operator, although this assumption is not crucial. This imperative operator and 'want' will then compose with their complements in a similar way, yielding the compositional structures for ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases that are illustrated in (30). Thus, if we have the situation-less ABSTAIN structure, we require simply that there are no closet-opening events by the addressee/speaker whatsoever in any of the accessible worlds. There is no viewpoint aspect, and IPFV_{vac} is inserted as the morphosyntactic default. But if we have the situation-full AVOID structure, we have viewpoint aspect. Then if we have imperfective, we require that there are no situations in any of the accessible worlds—basically, no “snapshots” that one could take of those worlds—whose runtime would be contained within the runtime of any closet-opening event by the addressee/speaker. If we have perfective, we require that that there are no such “snapshots” that would “capture” the culmination of any closet-opening event by the addressee/speaker.

- (30) a. ABSTAIN (no viewpoint aspect; IPFV_{vac} is the morphosyntactic default):
 $\llbracket \text{'not open.IPFV}_{vac}.IMP \text{ closet!}' / \text{'I not want open.IPFV}_{vac}.INF \text{ closet}' \rrbracket = 1$ in w
iff:
 $\forall w' R_{imp/want} w. \neg \exists e. e \subseteq w' \wedge \text{open}(e) \wedge \text{ag}(e) = \text{addr/sp} \wedge \text{th}(e) = \iota x. \text{closet}(x)$
- b. AVOID (there is viewpoint aspect; we can have IPFV_{sit} or PFV):
(i) $\llbracket \text{'not open.IPFV}_{sit}.IMP \text{ closet!}'^{10} / \text{'I not want open.IPFV}_{sit}.INF \text{ closet}' \rrbracket = 1$
in w iff:
 $\forall w' R_{imp/want} w. \neg \exists s. s \subseteq w' \wedge \exists e. \text{rt}(s) \subseteq \text{rt}(e) \wedge e \circ s \wedge e \subseteq w' \wedge \text{open}(e) \wedge \text{ag}(e) = \text{addr/sp} \wedge \text{th}(e) = \iota x. \text{closet}(x)$
- (ii) $\llbracket \text{'not open.PFV}.IMP \text{ closet!}' / \text{'I not want open.PFV}.INF \text{ closet}' \rrbracket = 1$ in w
iff:
 $\forall w' R_{imp/want} w. \neg \exists s. s \subseteq w' \wedge \exists e. \text{culm}(e) \subseteq \text{rt}(s) \wedge e \circ s \wedge e \subseteq w' \wedge \text{open}(e) \wedge \text{ag}(e) = \text{addr/sp} \wedge \text{th}(e) = \iota x. \text{closet}(x)$

As for 'fear', here we need to start by acknowledging that the difference in meaning between ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases is more complex than in the other two cases. In ABSTAIN cases, 'fear' simply encodes a relation between its subject and its complement (propositional or not) in the world of evaluation. However, in AVOID cases, 'fear' expresses the epistemic possibility

¹⁰As discussed earlier in subsection 2.2, while this structure should in principle be possible, it is not really attested—for reasons also discussed there.

of its propositional complement, as well as the speaker’s “fearful” attitude towards it.¹¹ In fact, it is only cases with infinitival complements of ‘fear’ that are ambiguous in Russian; a finite complement would unambiguously have the second interpretation only. (Cf. in English: *I am afraid that I will open the closet* only has the second interpretation.)

The compositional structures we get in ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases with ‘fear’ are then illustrated in (31). In (31a), we simply require that the subject of ‘fear’ (in this case, the speaker) stands in a ‘fearful’ relation towards the set of worlds in which there is any kind of event of them opening the closet (note that here I assume that the complement of ‘fear’ is a proposition, but it could very well be a property of events; this assumption is not crucial). In (31b), we require that (i) there is at least one world compatible with the beliefs of the subject of ‘fear’ in the world of evaluation w (which I simply write as $\exists w' R_{bel} w$) such that it contains a situation that in turn “captures” a closet-opening event by the subject of ‘fear’ in the way specified by the viewpoint aspect, and that (ii) the subject of ‘fear’ stands in a ‘fearful’ relation towards any worlds that contain such a situation.

- (31) a. ABSTAIN (no viewpoint aspect; IPFV_{vac} is the morphosyntactic default):
 $\llbracket \text{'I fear open.IPFV}_{vac}. \text{INF closet}' \rrbracket = 1$ in w iff
 $\text{fear}(\text{sp}, \lambda w'. \exists e. e \subseteq w' \wedge \text{open}(e) \wedge \text{ag}(e) = \text{sp} \wedge \text{th}(e) = \iota x. \text{closet}(x), w)$
- b. AVOID (there is viewpoint aspect; we can have IPFV_{sit} or PFV):
 $\llbracket \text{'I fear open.}\{\text{IPFV}_{sit}/\text{PFV.INF}\} \text{ closet}' \rrbracket = 1$ in w iff
 $\exists w' R_{bel} w. \exists s. s \subseteq w' \wedge \exists e. \{\text{rt}(s) \subseteq \text{rt}(e)/\text{culm}(e) \subseteq \text{rt}(s)\} \wedge e \circ s \wedge e \subseteq w' \wedge$
 $\text{open}(e) \wedge \text{ag}(e) = \text{sp} \wedge \text{th}(e) = \iota x. \text{closet}(x)] \wedge$
 $\text{fear}(\text{sp}, \lambda w''. \exists s. s \subseteq w'' \wedge \exists e. \{\text{rt}(s) \subseteq \text{rt}(e)/\text{culm}(e) \subseteq \text{rt}(s)\} \wedge e \circ s \wedge e \subseteq w' \wedge$
 $\text{open}(e) \wedge \text{ag}(e) = \text{sp} \wedge \text{th}(e) = \iota x. \text{closet}(x), w)$

3.6. Indefinite licensing

As I anticipated above, the situation layer in AVOID cases is precisely the thing that allows us to re-license dependent indefinites (*nibud'*) under negation, as it “shields” them from being anti-licensed. Let us unpack this now.

The exact licensing conditions of Russian *nibud'* indefinites have been a subject of some debate (see, e.g., Yanovich 2005; Pereltsvaig 2008; Zanon 2022). I have been calling them *dependent indefinites* in this paper following an existing tradition in the literature, which is based on the intuition that such indefinites need to “depend” on something, with a potential to co-vary (see, e.g., Pereltsvaig 2008 specifically). However, the exact formulation of the licensing conditions for *nibud'* indefinites does not matter for the purposes of this paper. What matters is that empirically, *nibud'* indefinites are licensed in imperatives and under ‘want’, as shown in (32). (Under the ‘co-variance’ intuition then, they are licensed, because they can co-vary with the worlds that are being quantified over in these environments—but again, this is not crucial for the present purposes.)

¹¹I believe that, at least by default, the epistemic possibility component is at-issue, and the attitude component is not, although this is not really relevant for our purposes. I do, however, think that this at-issue vs. not-at-issue distinction is pragmatic, and, thus, don’t encode it lexically. Note also that this lexical ambiguity of ‘fear’ is what Zalaznjak (2006) actually focuses on in her discussion of this verb in Russian; she only mentions the aspect facts briefly.

- (32) a. Pozvoni komu-nibud'!
 call.PFV.IMP who-NIBUD'
 'Call someone!' (low-scope reading of 'someone' only)
- b. Ja xoču komu-nibud' pozvonit'!
 I want call.PFV.INF who-NIBUD'
 'I want to call someone.' (low-scope reading of 'someone' only)

Ni NCIs are licensed by—local enough—negation. Now, what is meant by “local enough”? Clausemate negation is definitely local enough—in fact, Russian being a strict negative concord language, all indefinites in the scope of clausemate negation must surface as *ni* NCIs. Matrix negation is definitely not local enough to license *ni* NCIs in indicative finite embedded clauses. As for infinitival embedded clauses, as we already saw in (2)–(3), matrix negation can license *ni* NCIs there, but *ni* NCIs are only obligatory in ABSTAIN cases, whereas in AVOID cases, either *ni* NCIs or dependent *nibud'* are licensed (and for some speakers, there is a dispreference for *ni* NCIs). Licensing of *ni* NCIs in subjunctive embedded clauses by matrix negation is even more complicated even without the ABSTAIN vs. AVOID distinction, so I will set it aside for the purposes of this paper.

Now, I assume that, when licensed, *ni* NCIs block *nibud'* indefinites. I then propose that the situation layer blocks *ni*-NCI licensing (the negation is no longer local enough) and by doing so re-licenses *nibud'* indefinites.

Thus, in the ABSTAIN cases of negative imperatives and ‘not want’ with infinitival complements, only *ni* NCIs are licensed, but in the AVOID cases, either *ni* NCIs or *nibud'* indefinites can be licensed in principle, depending on whether the indefinite scopes above or below the situation layer, as shown schematically in (33).

- (33) a. *ni*:
 (i) $\forall w' R w \neg [\boxed{\exists x} \exists e]$ or
 (ii) $\forall w' R w \neg [\boxed{\exists x} \exists s \exists e]$
- b. *nibud'*: $\forall w' R w \neg [\exists s \boxed{\exists x} \exists e]$

I remain agnostic as to whether some speakers seem to generally disprefer the structure in (33a-ii) (as noted in footnote 3) for syntactic reasons, or there is some competition-related pragmatic reason, or something else is at play, or some combination of these reasons applies. The important thing is that both structures are in principle available, and then additional factors can affect their relative acceptability.

Going back to indefinites under ‘fear’, as a reminder, only free choice (e.g., *libo*), but not dependent (*nibud'*) indefinites are licensed in ABSTAIN cases, but both are licensed in AVOID cases. As far as I can tell, situations don’t seem to play a role in explaining this contrast. ABSTAIN-type ‘fear’ doesn’t license *nibud'* indefinites simply because there is no licenser for them (under the ‘co-variance’ intuition, that would be because there is nothing for them to “depend on”, i.e., co-vary with, in these cases). Instead, we simply express that the attitude holder stands in a ‘fearful’ relation to something (be it an individual, a set of individuals, a set of events, a proposition, etc.). In contrast, AVOID-type ‘fear’ licenses *nibud'* indefinites thanks to its epistemic possibility component. Again, regardless of the exact reasons why this component is a suitable licenser for *nibud'* indefinites, what matters for us is that empirically,

nibud' indefinites are licensed by epistemic possibility modality across the board, as shown in (34).

- (34) Vozmožno, Viktor pozvonil komu-nibud'.
 possibly Viktor called who-NIBUD'
 'Possibly, Viktor called someone.' (low-scope reading of 'someone' only)

Importantly, we don't want to say that the situation layer licenses *nibud'* indefinites in and of itself, as it's not like *nibud'* indefinites are licensed whenever we have meaningful viewpoint aspect. Having simple existential closure of events or situations or both is not enough for *nibud'* indefinites—as said above, they need the potential to co-vary. So the connection here is as follows. AVOID-type 'fear' has an epistemic possibility component, which licenses *nibud'* indefinites, and we also must have a situation layer in the complement of the AVOID-type 'fear', which results in having meaningful viewpoint aspect. ABSTAIN-type 'fear' doesn't have the epistemic possibility component, nor does it have the situation layer in its complement, so it doesn't license *nibud'* indefinites in and of itself (of course there can be other licensors in the structure), nor do we have meaningful viewpoint aspect in the complement of ABSTAIN-type 'fear', resulting in the imperfective being used as the morphosyntactic default.

I assume the main insights pursued in this section extend to anti-/re-licensing of *some* in English, although the details may vary, because the inventory and licensing conditions of English indefinites are substantially different from those in Russian.

Let me add a further important clarification to wrap up this subsection. It is the situation layer itself that has to block *ni*-NCI licensing in the relevant cases, not quantification over situations.¹² First, *kak-nibud'* can be used instead of *odnaždy* as a 'once'-type modifier,¹³ as shown in (35), and we wouldn't want to say that it licenses itself.

- (35) a. Ne {*otkryvaj / otkroj} kak-nibud' ètot škaf!
 not {*open.IPFV.IMP / open.PFV.IMP} how-NIBUD' this closet
 'Don't open this closet one day!' (only AVOID)
 b. Ja {ne xoču / bojus'} kak-nibud' {*otkryvat' / otkryt'} ètot
 I {not want / fear} how-NIBUD' {*open.IPFV.INF / open.PFV.INF} this
 škaf.
 closet
 '{I don't want to (accidentally) open the closet one day. / I am afraid of (accidentally) opening the closet one day.}' (only AVOID)

Second, *nikogda* 'never' NCI is incompatible with AVOID in the target environments, as shown in (36). We could explain it by saying that if a situation layer is present, existential temporal quantifiers bind *s* and can't emerge as *ni* NCIs. In other words, if a situation layer is present, temporal modifiers operate on *rt(s)* and, thus, can't outscope the situation layer.

- (36) a. Nikogda ne {otkryvaj / *otkroj} ètot škaf!
 NI-when not {open.IPFV.IMP / *open.PFV.IMP} this closet

¹²Thanks to Anna Szabolcsi and Hedde Zeijlstra (p.c.) for urging me to clarify this.

¹³*Kak-nibud'* is ambiguous between the 'in some manner' and 'on some occasion' interpretations; here I am focusing on the latter.

- ‘Never open this closet!’ (only ABSTAIN)
- b. Ja ne xoču nikogda {otkryvat’ / *otkryt’} ètot škaf.
 I not want NI-when {open.IPFV / *open.PFV} this closet
 ‘I don’t want to ever open this closet.’ (only ABSTAIN)

3.7. Pragmatics of prevention

We have now established the compositional differences between ABSTAIN and AVOID cases and have tied the aspect and indefinite distribution facts in Russian to those differences. But how do we explain the inferences about the amount of control that can be had over what the attitude holder wants to prevent in the two cases? Here the main insight is that in ABSTAIN vs. AVOID cases, the choice to have a situation layer is driven by global pragmatic considerations on how unwanted scenarios can/should be prevented. Let us elaborate on this insight.

Let me start by establishing an assumption that introducing a situation layer (when it is not obligatory for syntactic reasons) needs to be justified. Next, I am going to pursue the following intuitions. First, in all three environments at hand, we directly or indirectly infer that the speaker (imperatives) or experiencer (‘not want’, ‘fear’) considers certain scenarios undesirable. Second, in the case of accomplishments, this attitude can be about a certain outcome (event culmination) or about the activity (potentially) leading to it. If the attitude is about the activity rather than the outcome, we don’t need to include the event culmination and will thus have imperfective no matter what. If the attitude is about the outcome, whether we include the event culmination in our description (and, thus, have to introduce a situation layer) depends on whether we think it is possible to “nip it in the bud”.

Let us unpack these intuitions by looking at the examples in (37).

- (37) a. Ne {otkryvaj / *otkroj} ètu dver’! Spinu nadorvëš’.
 not {open.IPFV.IMP / *open.PFV.IMP} this door back strain.FUT.2SG
 ‘Don’t [try to] open this door! You’ll strain your back.’
- b. Ne {otrkyvaj / otkroj (slučajno)} ètu dver’! Za nej
 not {open.IPFV.IMP / open.PFV.IMP (accidentally)} this door behind it
 monstr.
 monster
 ‘Don’t {[intentionally] / (accidentally)} open this door! There’s a monster behind it.’

In (37a), I don’t want the addressee to partake in any door opening whatsoever because of the potential risk of the activity itself and, thus, go for an unsituated event description (ABSTAIN). Of course, this is only a reasonable desire if I assume that the addressee is in control over whether they engage in any door-opening events whatsoever. In (37b), I don’t want the end-state of the door being open to obtain. If I think that this outcome can be prevented by the relevant agent not engaging in any door-opening events whatsoever, I should go for an unsituated event description (ABSTAIN). If I don’t think that all such events can be prevented (e.g., the activity leading to the end-state cannot be controlled or even always recognized as such), I have to go for a situation description containing the end-state (AVOID).

Note once again, that as discussed before in subsection 2.2, once some part of what you

want to prevent is such that it cannot be fully controlled, you have to go for a situation description instead of unsituated events. And then, once you make the choice to have a situation layer, all your predicates within that clause will have meaningful viewpoint aspect—even those that describe events that can be controlled (see the examples in (6)–(7)).

4. A few more notes on Russian aspect

In this section, I provide a few further notes on imperfective vs. perfective in Russian that connect to the view of this distinction pursued in this paper.

First, let us look at aspect in non-negative imperatives in Russian. The effects of imperfective vs. perfective aspect in Russian imperatives can be quite varied and are non-trivial to capture under a simplistic binary view of the semantics and pragmatics of the imperfective vs. perfective distinction. For instance, imperfective imperatives can be used to issue permissions, as in (38-i), thus, contrasting with perfective commands, as in (38-ii).¹⁴ They can also convey—or at least be compatible with—a lack of urgency, as in (39a), or the exact opposite, as in (39b).

- (38) A: Možno ja doem tort?
 may I eat-up.PFV.FUT.1SG cake
 ‘May I finish the cake?’
 B: (i) Doedaj.
 eat-up.IMP.IPFV
 ≈‘Sure, finish it.’ (permission)
 (ii) Snačala sup doš’!
 first soup eat-up.IMP.PFV
 ‘First, finish the soup!’ (command)
- (39) a. Vstavaj potixon’ku.
 get-up.IPFV.IMP gradually
 ≈‘Start the process of getting up.’ (no urgency)
 b. Vstavaj nemedlenno!
 get-up.IPFV.IMP immediately
 ‘Get up now!’ (very urgent)

This assortment of facts is hard to account for if, for instance, we treat all imperfective imperatives as requests or permissions to initiate the relevant event, without any commitment about whether the event should be completed. This view does work straight-forwardly in (39a), as those can indeed be treated as requests to initiate the relevant event only, with no commitment about the event’s culmination. We can also make it work for urgent requests as in (39b), if we assume that these are about the immediate situation, meaning the $rt(s)$ is right now, so the culmination ends up outside $rt(s)$ precisely because of their urgency. Imperative forms in Russian aren’t marked for tense, but we can think of these hyper-urgent cases as present-oriented directives (the $rt(s)$, i.e., the time to comply, is the utterance time), as opposed to future-oriented directives.¹⁵

¹⁴Perfective permissions are also possible, although I feel more pressure to signal that they are permissions and not commands intonationally and/or by adding something like ‘if you want to’.

¹⁵Cf. also the past tense non-imperative directives, as in (i), which are very urgent and also rude; the

However, it's unclear how to make this view work for imperfective permissions like in (38-i). On the one hand, this permission isn't to just initiate the process of finishing the cake. In fact, if we say that it is, we might end up predicting an undesirable inference that completing finishing the cake is not permitted. On the other hand, there is no urgency on the part of the speaker, so we don't want to say that the reason such permissions have imperfective is because the *rt(s)* is right now. In other words, permissions like (38-i) cross-cut the distinction in the previous paragraph in a way that is not easy to capture under the binary view of imperfective vs. perfective presented above.

However, under the view pursued in this paper, we have another option, which is the use of imperfective as a morphosyntactic default that we insert when there is no viewpoint aspect and we just have an unsituated event description. This option ostensibly works well for permissions, as we simply allow any events of this kind (culminating or not), without tying them to any reference time (no urgency).

The next note is about semelfactives and minimizers. Semelfactive perfective verbs aren't always associated with unintentional actions in the environments at hand. Thus, in (40), we don't get an inference that casting a glance at him would be accidental.

- (40) a. Už i ne vzgljani na nego!
 already MIN not look.PFV-SEMELF.IMP at him
 ≈‘You can't even cast a single glance at him!’
 b. Ja bojus {i / daže} vzgljanut' na nego.
 I fear {MIN / even} look.PFV-SEMELF.INF at him
 ‘I am afraid of casting even a single glance at him.’

One intuition we could pursue here is that in minimizer contexts, the smallest possible events need to be prevented, and semelfactives describe just such events, with no further internal structure.

Finally, imperative forms can be used in counterfactuals in Russian,¹⁶ including under negation, in a way that does not necessarily imply wanting to prevent (or assure) anything. Such imperative forms are always part of situation descriptions, and their aspect is thus determined solely by the placement of the events they describe relative to *rt(s)*, as illustrated in (41).

- (41) a. Ne otkroj ja dver' tak bystro, xuligany by uspeli
 not open.PFV.IMP I door so fast pranksters SUBJ have-time.SUBJ
 ubežat'.
 run-away.INF
 ‘Had I not opened the door so fast, the pranksters would've had time to run away.’

intuition here then would be that the best time to comply, i.e., the *rt(s)*, would have been in the past.

(i) Vstal i vyšel!
 get-up.PAST.MASC.SG and leave.PAST.MASC.SG
 ‘Get up and leave!’ (lit.: ‘Got up and left!’)

¹⁶See, e.g., Zanon 2024 for an overview of non-directive uses of imperative forms in Russian.

- b. Ne otkryvaj ja dver' tak gromko, Saša by ne prosnulas'.
 not open.IPFV.IMP I door so loud Sasha SUBJ not wake-up.SUBJ
 'Had I not been opening the door so loudly, Sasha wouldn't have woken up.'

5. Conclusion

In this paper, I have proposed a unified, principled account of aspect and indefinite distribution facts from Russian in a natural class of environments, which are sensitive to the same pragmatic considerations about preventability. While the focus of this paper was on these specific grammatical reflexes in this specific language, I have also demonstrated that this is a more general phenomenon across languages, so this paper can provide an empirical and analytical framework for describing and accounting for such grammatical reflexes cross-linguistically. Even more generally, I view this work as part of a larger research endeavor aiming to elucidate the interaction between (i) clause size and structure, (ii) presence of events, situations, and/or worlds in the compositional structure, and (iii) pragmatics of how the event participants are viewed within a given situation.

References

- Bogusławski, Andrej. 1985. The problem of the negated imperative in perfective verbs revisited. *Russian Linguistics* 225–239.
- Champollion, Lucas. 2015. The interaction of compositional semantics and event semantics. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 38(1). 31–66. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10988-014-9162-8>.
- Despić, Miloje. 2016. Negative imperatives, aspect and agree: From locality to argument structure. Talk given at LinG colloquium.
- Despić, Miloje. 2020. Negative imperatives and aspect: a phase-based approach. In Peter Kosta & Teodora Radeva-Bork (eds.), *Current developments in Slavic linguistics: Twenty years after (based on selected papers from FDSL 11)*, 173–185. Bern: Peter Lang.
- Esipova, Maria. 2021a. On abstinence and avoidance. Talk given at *Agency and Intentions in Language (AIL) 1*, University of Göttingen. URL <https://esipova.net/files/esipova-ail1-hdt.pdf>.
- Esipova, Maria. 2021b. Semantics of situations and pragmatics of prevention. Talk given at *Slavic Linguistics Colloquium*, Humboldt University of Berlin. URL <https://esipova.net/files/esipova-slc2021-hdt.pdf>.
- Farkas, Donka F. 1992. On obviation. In Ivan A Sag & Anna Szabolcsi (eds.), *Lexical matters*, 85–109. Stanford, CA: CSLI Publications.
- Goncharov, Julie. 2018. Intentionality effect in imperatives. In *Proceedings of Formal Approaches to Slavic Linguistics (FASL) 27*, Michigan Slavic Publications.
- Goncharov, Julie. 2020. Dynamic presupposition of 'want' and polarity sensitivity. In Joseph Rhyne, Kaelyn Lamp, Nicole Dreier & Chloe Kwon (eds.), *Proceedings of Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT) 30*, 779–800. <https://doi.org/10.3765/salt.v30i0.4823>.
- Goncharov, Julie. 2025. Decisive modality and intentionality effect. *Canadian Journal of Linguistics* 70(1). 128–160. <https://doi.org/10.1017/cnj.2025.10006>.
- Haspelmath, Martin. 1997. *Indefinite pronouns*. Oxford University Press.
- Kaufmann, Magdalena. 2012. *Interpreting imperatives*. Dordrecht: Springer. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-94-007-2269-9>.

- Kratzer, Angelika. 2021. Situations in natural language semantics. In Edward N Zalta (ed.), *The Stanford encyclopedia of philosophy*, Metaphysics Research Lab, Stanford University Winter 2021 edn.
- Pereltsvaig, Asya. 2008. Russian *nibud'*-series as markers of co-variation. In Natasha Abner & Jason Bishop (eds.), *Proceedings of the West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL) 27*, 370–378. Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press.
- Reichenbach, Hans. 1947. *Elements of symbolic logic*. New York: Macmillan Co.
- Ruwet, Nicolas. 1984. Je veux partir/*Je veux que je parte. À propos de la distribution des complétives à temps fini et des compléments à l'infinitif en français. *Cahiers de grammaire* (7). 75–138.
- Schlenker, Philippe. 2005. The lazy Frenchman's approach to the subjunctive: Speculations on reference to worlds and semantic defaults in the analysis of mood. In Twan Geerts, Ivo van Ginneken & Haike Jacobs (eds.), *Romance languages and linguistic theory 2003: Selected papers from 'going romance'*, 269–309. John Benjamins Publishing Company. <https://doi.org/10.1075/cilt.270.15sch>.
- Szabolcsi, Anna. 2004. Positive polarity–negative polarity. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 22(2). 409–452. <https://doi.org/10.1023/B:NALA.0000015791.00288.43>.
- Szabolcsi, Anna. 2021. Obviation in hungarian: what is its scope, and is it due to competition? *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics* 6(1). <https://doi.org/10.5334/gjgl.1421>.
- Yanovich, Igor. 2005. Choice-functional series of indefinite pronouns and hamblin semantics. In Efthymia Georgala & Jonathan Howell (eds.), *Proceedings of Semantics and Linguistic Theory (SALT) 15*, 309–326. <https://doi.org/10.3765/salt.v0i0.2921>.
- Zaliznjak, Anna. 2006. *Mnogoznačnosť v jazyke i sposoby ee predstavlenija*. Moscow: Jazyki Slavjanskix kul'tur.
- Zanon, Ksenia. 2022. Wh-indefinites in Russian. In Berit Gehrke, Denisa Lenertová, Roland Meyer, Daria Seres, Luka Szucsich & Joanna Zaleska (eds.), *Advances in formal Slavic linguistics*, 657–689. Berlin: Language Science Press. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.15394207>.
- Zanon, Ksenia. 2024. Narrative imperatives and adjacent phenomena. In *Advances in formal Slavic linguistics*, To appear.
- Zinova, Yulia & Hana Filip. 2014. Scalar implicatures of Russian verbs. In Małgorzata Szajbel-Keck, Roslyn Burns & Darya Kavitskaya (eds.), *Proceedings of Formal Approaches to Slavic Linguistics (FASL) 23*, 382–401.